

AGRICULTURAL EXTENSION IN MALAWI*

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Malawi is a small country by most standards, the total land acreage amounting to over 23 million acres. Of this 23 million acres, the maximum available for agriculture is put in the region of 13 million acres. This is already quite a cut in total land acreage and does indicate that there might be a problem of finding land for the food needs of the country. However, when these figures are set in the light of projected population of between 5 million (at 2.5 per cent growth rate) and 5 1/2 million (at 3.3 per cent growth rate) in 1975, rising to 6 1/2 million (at 2.5 per cent growth rate) and 7 1/2 million (at 3.3 per cent growth rate) in 1985 (Malawi 1969), it becomes more apparent that there is likely to be very high demands on the usable land within the country. The country's contention (1971a) that only 1 1/4 million acres of land possible for agriculture remain unused is true, then it is quite feasible to ask if there is already a land problem in Malawi with the consequent queries about food and crop sufficiency.

Because of the nature and distribution of resources in Malawi, the Government has decided in its Statement of Development Policies 1971-1980 (1971d) that the national development efforts must be concentrated on small-scale agriculture. When one sees that in 1970 the average Gross Domestic Product (GDP) per head of population was K60, of which K38 was cash, one is to realise the enormity of the problem and challenge that lies ahead.

The main way in which it is planned to develop Malawi is by developing national agriculture, which has just barely left the subsistence barter stage, a buoyant industry which will be the foundation on which all other development can be built. Is enough technical information available to do this? If all the which had been discovered since, say, 1950 in both agriculture and soil conservation had been applied in Malawi, there is no doubt but that Malawi would be of the leading agricultural countries in Africa today. If, then, the information and technology have been available for so long, why is it that in 1970 the GDP was so low? The problem was, and is, that of trying to get traditional farmers to adopt their agricultural methods to achieve improvement. As Clark

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